

S05-01 - The Open Vale Site

Player text

The clearing is a perfect circle, the only break in the endless canopy: open sky above for the first time in days. The Custodian speaks softly as you arrive. This is where she first forged the ward pillars that keep Hush safe. She almost died doing it. Then her antennae perk in a disconcerting way. "This is good. Stop, here. Now come help me. I'm old." She begins to glow. "I'll need an hour. Enjoy the night air while you can. We'll be very busy soon."

Public objective

Reach the ritual site, learn what is coming, and prepare.

Raw source

- Id: S05-01
- Type: scene
- Sectionid: ACT-FIVE
- Sectiontitle: Act Five: The Ward Renewal
- Title: The Open Vale Site
- Shorttitle: Arrival / Short Rest
- Order: 601
- Playersafe: True
- Completioneligible: True
- Image: assets/scenes/S05-01-open-valetm-ritual-site.png
- Alt: Old ritual clearing under open sky.
- Caption: The quiet before the finale turns care, rest, and preparation into real protection.
- Mood: The Ward Renewal
- Gmgoal: Arrive at the old ritual clearing, run the last Short Rest, and turn preparation into finale resources.
- Publicobjective: Reach the ritual site, learn what is coming, and prepare.
- Readaloud: The clearing is a perfect circle, the only break in the endless canopy: open sky above for the first time in days. The Custodian speaks softly as you arrive. This is where she first forged the ward pillars that keep Hush safe. She almost died doing it. Then her antennae perk in a disconcerting way. "This is good. Stop, here. Now come help me. I'm old." She begins to glow. "I'll need an hour. Enjoy the night air while you can. We'll be very busy soon."
- Gmnotes: This is the pressure valve before the finale. Give every player one prep spotlight before moving on.
- Gmscript: Say: "This is your last calm moment. Short Rest now: Tend to Wounds, Clear Stress, Repair Armor, or Prepare for Hope. Pick two. If you Prepare together, you each get two Hope. I take 1d4 Fear during the rest."
- Gmreadaloud: The clearing is a perfect circle, the only break in the endless canopy. The Custodian says this is where she first forged the ward pillars that keep Hush safe. "I'll need an hour. Enjoy the night air while you can. We'll be very busy

soon."

- Gmchecklist: Deliver the clearing and Custodian history beat. Run Short Rest: Tend to Wounds, Clear Stress, Repair Armor, Prepare. Take 1d4 Fear during the rest. If ritual_prep=ready, let a prepared PC preview the countdown before S05-02. If package_status=lost, state that the ritual cannot proceed as written until a recovery/improvisation decision is made.
- Gmprivate: The Forgotten Gods deflection is canon-facing; do not explain the deeper cost. The player-facing site is warm Open Vale. Open Vale(TM) registration stays GM-only.
- Playertakeaway: This is the quiet before the worst of it; use it well.
- Storytakeaway: This clearing is where the ward was born and where it must be renewed, and the Custodian is risking herself again.
- Mechanictakeaway: Short Rest is the final resource conversion: HP, Stress, Armor, Hope, ritual_prep, and GM Fear all change the fight.
- Rollcards: s05-01-read-the-open-vale-pattern S05-01 Read the Open Vale pattern Read the Open Vale pattern Knowledge Instinct Knowledge Instinct 14 Knowledge reads the circle; Instinct feels what the clearing excludes. The ritual starts without a clear defensive map. Critical Success: best possible version of the action; gain Hope and clear 1 Stress. Add an extra benefit that follows from the fiction. Success with Hope: the PC gets what they wanted and gains Hope. Keep the position clean or generous. Success with Fear: the PC gets what they wanted, but the GM gains Fear and introduces a cost, complication, or pressure. Failure with Hope: the PC does not get the full result, but gains Hope and receives a useful thread, clue, or safer next option. Failure with Fear: the PC fails and the GM gains Fear. Make a hard move that follows from the fiction. The ritual starts without a clear defensive map. Use a hard complication, lost time, worse position, GM Fear, or mark Stress. Apply an official condition only if the fiction and rules justify it. The attempt falls short, but a partial thread appears. Offer one clue, weak position, or safer follow-up. The PC gets the core result, but it costs time...
- Entityids: open-valetm-ritual-site keystone-asset forgotten-gods the-stones-of-the-vale whitefire-custodian goldspire-territories ritual-countdown route-assurance-contract marlowe-fairwind sealed-keystone-crate ward-moths sunfire-lily mist-things
- Entities: open-valetm-ritual-site Open Vale? Ritual Site location Location assets/icons/location.png assets/location-visuals/open-valetm-ritual-site/profile_scene_v02.png OH-pen vayl RICH-oo-ul site An ancient circular clearing of standing stones and ward-light, with a freshly painted company marker staked at its edge. Make the final arena feel sacred, neglected, and operational all at once. Ancient circular clearing rebranded by Goldspire; where the ward renewal happens.; introduce it with a sensory palette, who feels safe there, and what has been neglected. Pull player attention toward the choices, clues, and relationships tied to Whitefire Custodian, Keystone Asset, Legacy Security Skeleton. Ancient circular clearing rebranded by Goldspire; where the ward renewal happens. keystone-asset Keystone Asset? item Item / Asset assets/icons/item.png assets/item-images/keystone-asset/profile_base.png KEE-stohn ASS-et Inside the sealed crate, packed in wax-paper and reassurance, sits a heavy grey stone the size of a loaf, warm to the touch, faintly humming, with a light deep inside it that is slowly going out. Keystone Asset?, Emeris Crown Holdings: the ward-stone that keeps Emeris safe. It is...
- Locationids: open-valetm-ritual-site the-stones-of-the-vale

- Itemids: keystone-asset whitefire-ward-charm
- Clueids: route-assurance-contracttm public-private-ward-compact
- Statecontrols: ritual_prep Ritual Prep select unready ready keystone_understanding Keystone Understanding select surface deep strixwolf_disposition Strixwolf Disposition select unresolved calm hostile killed strixwolf_outcome Strixwolf Outcome select unresolved calmed helped avoided attacked killed strixwolf_trust Strixwolf Trust number 3 strixwolf_blood_debt Strixwolf Blood Debt checkbox
 bramble_outcome Bramble Outcome select unresolved killed captured spared negotiated
 escaped let_cargo bramble_truth_learned Bramble Truth Learned checkbox
 package_status Package Status select held lost hush_trust Hush Trust select low
 neutral high custodian_route Custodian Route select unknown safe dangerous
 ward_awareness Ward Awareness select none seed aware festival_boon Festival Boon
 select none charm favor market_find goodwill custodian_trust Custodian Trust select
 low neutral high ward_stability Ward Stability select fragile stable hush_clues Hush
 Clues select none custodian_route ward_seed corporate_seam farm_seed market_rumor
 multiple
- Mechanicids: countdown short-rest adversary-spotlight fear hope stress presence
 knowledge
- Playerquestions: Who do you prepare beside? What do you repair, confess, steady, or
 set down before this begins? Who explains the plan to the group?
- Relationshipprompts: Which PC quietly checks on someone else here? Who disagrees
 about the right thing to do without breaking trust?
- Ownershipprompt: Name one detail in Open Vale? Ritual Site that belongs to your
 character's point of view.
- Fearsponds: Spend Fear to tick the ritual countdown, expose the Custodian, activate
 ward backlash, or trigger Market Correction. Tick the Ritual Countdown the wrong
 direction or expose the Custodian. Trigger Market Correction, Pass-Through, Memory
 Delve, or Group Attack when fiction supports it.
- Choicesconsequences: Tend to Wounds. A PC or ally clears 1d4+1 HP. Use the Short
 Rest option now. More bodies stay standing during S05-03 through S05-05. ritual_prep
 can still become ready if the table also plans. Reward: survival cushion. player-
 visible Clear Stress. A PC clears 1d4+1 Stress. Use the Short Rest option now.
 Memory Delve and peak pressure hurt less later. protected_whom can still be written
 later. Reward: emotional/mechanical resilience. player-visible Repair Armor. A PC
 repairs 1d4+1 armor slots. Use the Short Rest option now. Group Attack and peak hits
 are less punishing. ward_stability still controls ritual pressure. Reward: damage
 cushion. player-visible Prepare together. The party banks Hope and makes a plan.
 Gain Hope; if prepared together, each participating PC gets 2 Hope.
 ritual_prep=ready and S05-02 countdown rules can be taught diegetically.
 ritual_prep=ready Reward: stronger opening; GM still gains 1d4 Fear. player-visible
 package_status=lost warning. The table sees the missing package matters before the
 ritual starts. Recovery, substitution, or acceptance of a fragile alternate start is
 required. Without Kyle's canon ruling, this remains flagged rather than silently...
- Lootclues: Open Vale residue after the ritual Keystone Asset?: Inside the sealed
 crate, packed in wax-paper and reassurance, sits a heavy grey stone the size of a
 loaf, warm to the touch, faintly humming, with a light deep inside it that is slowly
 going out. Whitefire Custodian's Ward-Charms: A small hand-carved wooden ratcoon mid-
 scamper has been thumb-worn smooth for luck. It is warm, and the forest feels a

little kinder while you hold it.

- Handouts: Ward geometry
- Sources: S05-01-open-valetm-ritual-site
- Sourcefiles: dist/Act5_Upgrade_Packet/ACT5_SCENE_RESEARCH.md
dist/Act5_Upgrade_Packet/ACT5_PER_CHARACTER.md
- References: Act5 scene packet sources/Act5_Upgrade_Packet/ACT5_SCENE_RESEARCH.md
- Storyscope: Perceived antagonist: the forest. True antagonist: the corporate lie about the forest. The players never confront it directly. They are meant to feel it by the end. Every act offers at least one guaranteed and one earned hint that the danger is manufactured and the forest is not the enemy. Soul-Audit Wraiths bear audit glyphs and say, "Unlicensed soul-resonance detected. Submit for audit."
REFLAVOR GUARANTEED A defeated wraith leaves a Soulspire compliance tag or coil-credit token instead of natural remains. ADD GUARANTEED Wraiths ignore forest creatures and home only on ritual soul-magic. ADD EARNED Instinct Medium 15 A player can read the markings and name Soulspire without the GM naming it first. ADD EARNED Knowledge Medium 15 Optional flag: Legacy Skeletons carry scraps of old corporate credentials. FLAG SEED Instinct: target logic. Knowledge: read markings. ACT5 Act 5: Open Vale defense 200 2:40 to 3:20 3:20 countdown 8, skeletons, wraiths, Market Correction Lower the countdown start to 6; cap wraith reinforcements.
- Livetools: encounter S05-01 MAP-S05-03 pages/combat/s05-03.html
- Percharacterlayer: marlowe-fairwind Marlowe Fairwind Ritual briefing Recognizes the Open Vale as a true ritual site and understands the magnitude of what the Custodian is about to attempt. Knowledge 13 Grasps the countdown logic before it starts and senses the ward will take something to renew. Can brief the party diegetically without being required for the ritual. Marlowe, you understand this ritual better than anyone here. Want to brief the party on what's coming? khari-nix Khari Nix The watch Naturally turns the rest into a defensive plan: who stands where when it starts. Can set the guard order and make ritual_prep feel concrete. Khari, you can set the guard order now. Want to position the party around the Custodian before the fight? varian-soto Varian Soto The perimeter Reads the treeline and knows which directions the summoned things will come from. Instinct 13 Calls the threat lanes before S05-02 begins. Can make the first positioning beat feel earned. Varian, you can feel where the woods will spit out trouble. Want to call the threat lanes? garrick-reed Garrick Reed Rest leadership Knows how to make a last rest practical instead of sentimental. Can help the table choose Tend, Clear, Repair...
- Takeawayhelp: Player takeaway This is the quiet before the worst of it; use it well. "Last calm moment. Heal up, steady yourselves, and brace. Once she starts, it is all hands." "Patch a wound, shake off stress, fix armor, prepare with someone for Hope, or ask the Custodian one human question." Every player should leave S05-01 with a concrete prep choice made. short-rest hope fear stress Story takeaway This clearing is where the ward was born and where it must be renewed, and the Custodian is risking herself again. "Sacred ground. She made the ward here once, nearly died for it, and she is about to do it again with you to guard her." "If players ask about the Forgotten Gods, she deflects. The deeper cost stays a seed, not an answer." Keep the moment sincere. Save corporate bite for the report choice. short-rest hope fear stress Mechanic takeaway Short Rest is the final resource conversion: HP, Stress, Armor, Hope, ritual_prep, and GM Fear all change the fight. "Short Rest: pick two. Tend to Wounds clears 1d4+1 HP, Clear Stress clears 1d4+1 Stress, Repair Armor

restores 1d4+1 slots, Prepare gives Hope; prepare together for two Hope each. I take 1d4 Fear." "If ritual_prep is ready, you know the...

- Playerbeats: s05-01-circle Circle The perfect circle assets/scenes/S05-01-open-valetm-ritual-site.png Old ritual clearing under open sky. The clearing is a perfect circle under open sky, the first clean break in the canopy for days. The clearing is a perfect circle under open sky, the first clean break in the canopy for days. The clearing is a perfect circle under open sky, the first clean break in the canopy for days. text-first s05-01-history History Her history assets/scenes/S05-01-open-valetm-ritual-site.png Old ritual clearing under open sky. The Custodian says she forged the ward here once before, and it nearly killed her. The Custodian says she forged the ward here once before, and it nearly killed her. The Custodian says she forged the ward here once before, and it nearly killed her. text-first s05-01-rest Short Rest The last rest assets/scenes/S05-01-open-valetm-ritual-site.png Old ritual clearing under open sky. Short Rest now: heal, clear Stress, repair Armor, or Prepare for Hope before the fight begins. Short Rest now: heal, clear Stress, repair Armor, or Prepare for Hope before the fight begins. Short Rest now: heal, clear Stress, repair Armor, or Prepare for Hope before the...
- Gmbeats: s05-01-circle Circle The perfect circle Say: "The first beat is relief: open sky, a circle of grass, and old stones waiting for work." The clearing is a perfect circle under open sky, the first clean break in the canopy for days. The ritual site feels sacred before it feels tactical. Visual orientation prepares later map use. Players can picture the finale space. Player takeaway Players can picture the finale space. "The first beat is relief: open sky, a circle of grass, and old stones waiting for work." "The table-facing answer is: Players can picture the finale space." Use this beat to give the players one visible next action: protect the center, read the field, spend prep, name who they shield, or choose what truth leaves with them. table-spotlight Story takeaway The ritual site feels sacred before it feels tactical. "The first beat is relief: open sky, a circle of grass, and old stones waiting for work." "The story answer is: The ritual site feels sacred before it feels tactical." Tie the answer to a visible Act 5 consequence: the ward steadies, the Custodian suffers, Hush is protected, or the final report changes who owns the truth. table-spotlight Mechanic takeaway...
- Beatautoplayeligible: True
- Beatautoplaydefault: False
- Beatautoplayintervalms: 8000
- Playersafeprojection: S05-01 scene The Open Vale Site assets/scenes/S05-01-open-valetm-ritual-site.png Old ritual clearing under open sky. The quiet before the finale turns care, rest, and preparation into real protection. The Ward Renewal Reach the ritual site, learn what is coming, and prepare. The clearing is a perfect circle, the only break in the endless canopy: open sky above for the first time in days. The Custodian speaks softly as you arrive. This is where she first forged the ward pillars that keep Hush safe. She almost died doing it. Then her antennae perk in a disconcerting way. "This is good. Stop, here. Now come help me. I'm old." She begins to glow. "I'll need an hour. Enjoy the night air while you can. We'll be very busy soon." s05-01-circle Circle The perfect circle assets/scenes/S05-01-open-valetm-ritual-site.png Old ritual clearing under open sky. The clearing is a perfect circle under open sky, the first clean break in the canopy for days. The clearing is a perfect circle under open sky, the first clean break in the canopy for days. The

clearing is a perfect circle under open sky, the first clean break in the canopy for days. text-first s05-01-history History Her history...

- Companionmapids: MAP-S05-03 MAP-LOC-open-valetm-ritual-site MAP-LOC-goldspire-territories MAP-LOC-the-stones-of-the-vale
- Slidenumber: 62
- Totalslides: 110
- Spotlights: SPOT-M-SHORTREST short-rest short-rest M16 S05-01 high mandatory scene-enter Short Rest, Then Breathe This is the pre-finale resource checkpoint. Each PC chooses two rest moves: Tend to Wounds, Clear Stress, Repair Armor, or Prepare. Resolve recovery before the ritual pressure begins. After the rest tick, the GM banks 1d4 Fear. Short Rest wiki/mechanic/short-rest teach-by-example Make the pre-finale reset explicit and useful. mechanic defer-if-clock-critical True True
- Spotlightsummary: 1

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